Copyright Statement

The Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College has made a reasonable effort to secure permission from the interviewees to make these materials available to the public. Use of these materials by other parties is subject to the fair use doctrine in United States copyright law (Title 17, Chapter 1, section 107), which states that use by “reproduction in copies or phonorecords or by any other means specified by that section [106 and 106A], for purposes such as criticism, comment, news reporting, teaching (including multiple copies for classroom use), scholarship, or research, is not an infringement of copyright."

Any use that does not fall within fair use must be cleared with the rights holder. For assistance in contacting the rights holder please contact the Fillius Jazz Archive, Hamilton College, 198 College Hill Road, Clinton, NY 13323 (phone: 315-859-4071).

Marilyn Crispell

Marilyn Crispell is a pianist and composer who explores the boundaries of improvised music. She has collaborated with Anthony Braxton, Henry Grimes, and Reggie Workman, and has produced numerous recordings with her own trio. She received an Outstanding Alumni Award from the New England Conservatory of Music.

Marilyn was interviewed via Zoom on January 21, 2022 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive. I'm very pleased to have Marilyn Crispell with me today, a pianist and composer. I don't know what it's like in Woodstock but it's pretty cold here in Clinton. So I thought I'd warm you up with a quote about you from the *All Music Guide to Jazz*. And the reviewer was commenting on a recording you did called "Band on the Wall." Was that a duo recording?

MC: Yes that was a duo recording with a British drummer, Eddie Prevost.

MR: So this reviewer said: "A very talented pianist who can play with tremendous power and freedom. Also not afraid to ring out sincere emotions on straight ahead forward melodies. If you were able to write your own description of yourself, what would you like people to hear from you?

MC: Gosh. Well I try to play what is true for me, what comes from my heart, and that could be something that is very abstract with a lot of energy, it could be something very romantic, it could be lots of different things. And my hope is that I can travel seamlessly between them and that my voice still comes across as my voice, and you know, that it all sounds organic.

MR: That's a beautiful description. You often times are mentioned in the same paragraph as Cecil Taylor and do you recall trying to play like anybody in particular?

MC: Sure, lot of people. I think everybody does that, you know, you imitate the people you are attracted to musically and then your own voice kind of comes out of that. But it's almost like being a child and having to start somewhere and listening to your parents talk and imitating them before you can actually say anything. So Cecil Taylor was a huge, huge influence. And McCoy Tyner, who is actually probably the first one because of listening to "A Love Supreme." So he was a huge influence and for a long time I think my playing was very influenced by him and then when I heard Cecil it was like wow, yeah. You know?

MR: Do you happen to know a fellow named A.B. Spellman?

MC: Sure.

MR: I had the pleasure of chatting with him earlier this week and he was talking about Cecil Taylor and I was sort of happy to hear that he described Cecil as a man who was happy most of the time. And the reason I say that is because I think a lot of people feel that music that is described as free jazz is often angry or reactive. And I wonder how you feel about that?

MC: Yeah, I think that's a real oversimplification. I think that there definitely were political and sociological underpinnings to a lot of that movement and so possibly they're hearing some of that. But I know I read a review once of something of mine and they said why is Marilyn Crispell so angry and I was like what? I'm not angry. You know it's just about a particular energy and tonality and when I started playing more romantic music and more ballads, whatever, someone I had played with for a long time in the sort of free jazz movement said to me, "Why are you doing this? Where's the anger?" You know? And I think I know what they were talking about. They perceived it as anger but really I feel it's just the energy. It's strong energy. When I go back and listen to Cecil now I hear blues. I hear really intense rhythm and blues tonality and his influence from Horace Silver and all of this. When I first heard him I did not hear that. It just sounded very abstract with lots of energy and lots of notes. You know?

MR: Did you go to the piano and try to figure out how and — how is he able to sound like that?

MC: I felt a resonance with it so I felt like it was a direction I could go in easily you know, or what I thought I perceived, you know, at the time, I could go in that direction easily. More easily than say a more traditional jazz direction.

MR: I was watching a video of you and I was going to do this later but it seems relevant, with Anthony Braxton in Germany in a quartet setting. And as I watched I wondered if the emotion of joy and/or humor is possible in the kind of music you were playing because it seemed really intense and the concentration involved indicated perhaps that this was not fun.

MC: No it was tremendous fun.

MR: Well I'm glad you said that because I hoped to be corrected.

MC: Yeah, some of the most fun I've ever had playing. I mean Anthony is an amazing chess player. I think he even used to make a living playing chess in Washington Square Park. I might have dreamed that up but I think that's true. And playing his music, it was a challenge but it was a fun challenge, you know? And you definitely had to be on your toes all the time. But there was a lot of joy and humor and it was really, I think when we were — at least speaking for myself — when we were doing this we weren't thinking oh this is joyful, this is funny, this is angry. It was just about the music, purely about the music. And then these other things you sort of maybe notice as an afterthought.

MR: Well when you stood up to take a bow you were all smiling.

MC: Yeah.

MR: It makes me think of another CD book, *The Penguin Guide to Jazz* I looked up Anthony Braxton and it said: "If Marilyn Crispell is on it buy it."

MC: Really?

MR: Yes.

MC: Nice.

MR: Two compliments. So you came from — into this field as a classical player, is that correct?

MC: Originally, originally yes. But most of the time I was playing classical music I was also improvising for modern dance classes and I did that as a job for years. So that was — yeah I had some experience in improvising but it was a different kind of thing, you know there were boundaries to it, you are playing for this exercise and I would often do a repetitive kind of thing. And I remember the first time that I really improvised with someone else. It was a guitarist named Baird Hersey came over to my place and he said, "Just start playing and don't stop." So that was my modus operandi for years actually. And it was like jumping off a cliff, I was terrified, terrified. It was a terrifying experience the first time.

MR: To be terrified there has to be, in my opinion, a fear of doing something wrong. So what constitutes wrongness at that — do you recall what would have made it sound wrong to you? Were you playing chordally?

MC: No, I think it was pretty free. I might have been throwing a lot of fourth chords in there, things like that. But yeah, I think one of the reasons I love improvising is that you can't really do something wrong. I mean the closest I would feel I was coming to that would be well two things. If I would be playing somebody else's compositions and would improvise in a manner that was totally inappropriate to that — sorry — to that music; or if I was thinking too much and worrying about what I was doing rather than letting the music come through and sort of guiding it but not controlling it. That would be wrong in the sense of kind of being true to myself. You know and of course you could play wrong chords, there are a lot of wrong things you could do if you're playing somebody's compositions and then the improvising.

MR: Does — you have used the term "true" a few times. I'd like to delve into that a bit. Is it harder to stay true if you're playing with other people?

MC: No. No. It's just different. I mean if I'm playing alone I'm having a — well like that Bill Evans recording "Conversations with Myself" you know? And if I'm playing with somebody else I'm having a conversation with them. And I may have to play less than

what I would play if I were playing on my own, or the more people involved in a sense the less you are playing because you can't fill up all the space. You know?

MR: Space. Very important. And sometimes I feel like people forget that it is, especially younger players.

MC: Yeah, space and silence, that's really important. But oh you were asking me about being true when I'm playing with other people. Yeah it's a different thing because you're adjusting all the time to what other people are doing so if I'm playing with somebody and I don't hear something, if I don't feel something to play at that moment or if it feels like the best thing would be for there to be no piano at that moment, you know a change in the sound, then that would be true I guess. Although I'm using it in a deeper sense. I've heard people say often, well this is the music that I really hear but for now I'm going to do this other music because that will sort of get me across. And then when people know who I am then I'll do what I really want. And I'm thinking ut uh, because when people know who you are they know who you are for doing what was something you didn't really want to do. You know? I guess I'm talking more about that kind of thing.

MR: Yes. Was that a personal attitude you had years ago? Did you sort of think about that and make that decision?

MC: No. I just did what came most naturally to me. Maybe it was a little bit of a lazy thing you know. I took the path of least resistance.

MR: Can you expand on that? If someone had said, "I want you to come on this date and we're going to play some Ramsey Lewis covers," that wouldn't have been — I'm trying to connect the path of least resistance for you was to say yes or no to that?

MC: It would originally have been to say no to that. However, as the years have gone by I've felt more comfortable with many different aspects of the genre and I'm calling it jazz because it's really closer to what I think of as jazz than classical music. Because jazz involved improvisation and so did Baroque music and all that. And that's why the Swingle Singers were able to make such fantastic recordings of Bach by the way.

MR: It's funny you say that, I just heard them last night. I was doing research on you and somehow I stumbled upon the Swingle Singers doing an incredible, like eight singers, and I was reminded of how terrific that music was.

MC: Oh it's amazing. Fantastic.

MR: Is there a better term than free jazz for free jazz?

MC: I think just creative music. Creative music.

MR: Okay. I had the pleasure of talking to Karl Berger, this is from 2014, and I wanted your comment on something he said about, we'll just use the term free jazz. He says, "More freedom is not about less precision, it's about more precision. The more precise you get the more free you are. People think of free jazz and it's about oh yeah I can lose all these

rules. I'm creating my own rules and they're much more stringent than anybody can tell me from the outside."

MC: Yeah. I would agree with that. It's the old thing about freedom and license, you know? Total freedom is a scary thing because there's no structure. You have to create the structure. It's just like during Covid there's no work. I haven't gone out and played — maybe one or two concerts, that's it, for over two years. So I have this totally basically unstructured life you know, and that can be very, very difficult. When you're improvising I think it takes a lot of discipline maybe, self discipline, to create these structures as you go along, and it takes a lot of listening when you're playing with other people, a lot of serious listening. Not just everybody — not just a big free-for-all you know. Anthony Braxton once, after one of our tours, went home and — or at least this was the story he told, and his wife asked him where was the money. And he said, well it is free jazz. You know?

MR: Yeah. Are you able to — first I was going to say can you practice creativity — but I'll amend that. Are there things that you can do, especially with the lack of playing opportunities, that you can keep your creativity alive and growing?

MC: Yeah. I have to say there hasn't been a lot of motivation 'cause there's this underlying anxiety all the time and sense of surrealness or surreality. I don't know which of those is right. And I have written some new music and I've done a bunch of drawings. I started this book of abstract drawings and I would give myself some ideas like okay draw something with no straight lines, this or that. Different things. So now I have almost completely filled up this book with drawings and a little book of poetry of stuff I have written over the last forty years — just — you know nothing major just very personal stuff. Some friends of mine who have a small press published that, so that came out, and a lot of recordings that were in the can that I had done with other people they finally got around to mixing them and putting them out, you know, or they're close to coming out. So in that sense it was more for me like a tying up of loose ends than continuing with something new.

MR: Well you said you played for the dance classes and I'm wondering if you took some of those drawings, those abstract drawings and picked one out and put it on the piano in front of you, could you play the drawing?

MC: Yeah. I could. In fact, a few years ago some Scottish musicians and artists and some American musicians and I did a joint project here in Woodstock. We had an exhibition where we collaborated on the artwork and the music, we created these graphic scores. The Scottish artist whose name Jo Ganter, Josephine Ganter, and she created a lot of grid patterns and over those I drew some things and then the Scottish saxophone player who I've played with, Raymond MacDonald, he did other kinds of things on top of those grid

patterns. He filled them in with different colors and things so they were very different. And we had this whole exhibition of graphic scores, we wrote instructions of how they were to be played and went in the studio, I went in the studio and recorded a series of the ones that I had done with David Rothenberg who played clarinet and laptop electronics, and then these were all up on the wall with headphones so people could listen to the music we recorded to each one, each drawing, and then Jo created animations of them. So it was this incredible, wonderful project and was up for a couple of months here. And we're going to do another project this summer hopefully, up here.

MR: Yeah. I'm reminded of — I hope my memory is correct — I had an Anthony Braxton record in my memory it was a double LP, and some of his song titles were schematics.

MC: Yeah.

MR: I remember thinking well how would I request that song? You know it didn't have a word title.

MC: Well no, it would have been easier to request one of the ones that was like E-24 or A and that kind of thing. I guess you couldn't request them. I guess he didn't take requests.

MR: He didn't take requests. But was it his way — I don't want to make too much out of this — but was it his way of saying this music cannot be titled with words that will indicate what it's supposed to mean or be about?

MC: I don't know. He was very mysterious about it. All of those schematics actually meant something. They actually meant something. And letters and stuff like that. But he would never say what they meant. They meant — but they did mean something to him.

MR: Referring to that video I watched, there was some intense reading of music on the particular — that first number that was in this video from a German concert. I wonder, did he write in quote normal music notation?

MC: Yeah.

MR: Okay.

MC: Most of the stuff I played with him was written in normal so-called classical notation. Then there would maybe be some little squiggles to indicate so many seconds of improvising. Because as time went on he wrote more and he structured the improvisations more so that sometimes when he would be improvising I would be playing a written piano piece underneath it. And stuff like that. It was a real collage.

MR: And you were listening for cues as to when we're moving on?

MC: Mm hmm. Yeah, well it would be obvious. Okay his solo is winding down and now we're going on to the next section, whatever.

MR: Okay. I wanted to read two things if you'll bear with me for a moment. You did a marvelous interview with a woman named Molly Sheridan a number of years ago and you were telling her about your encounter with "A Love Supreme," John Coltrane's

masterpiece. And I'm just going to read a little bit of it followed by something that A.B. Spellman said. So this was from your quote: "It completely took me over, I felt a presence in the room and I felt connected to this presence which I felt to be the spirit of Coltrane. It was very emotional. I felt like we communicated, and I said something to the effect of please help me to enter into this and to learn and be a part of it." And A.B. said, about John Coltrane, "It was John Coltrane's commitment to change people with his music. His sense was if you will sit here and submit to what I am playing you will be a different and better person. He was asked what he was trying to accomplish with his music and said, 'I want to make people saints.'"

MC: Wow.

MR: When I read those two things I felt like well John certainly did reach you.

MC: And other people. Apparently I'm not the only one who had that experience with that particular recording. And it is called "A Love Supreme." And that feeling and that presence was ultimately about overwhelming love. It was a feeling of overwhelming love that brought me to tears. And that was why I wanted to be connected with the music and with the people playing it, even more so than the music itself.

MR: Well said. What is about him — I don't know if this is answerable — when I listen to him I feel very often that he's constantly searching. And I wonder if he ever felt that he found it?

MC: I don't know. I know he practiced constantly and he was always working on things. I would guess that he never like found it and that most creative people go on searching always, you know, that they never find it and that's it. They found it and that's it. You know? You're always going further and you don't know where the limits are. So I think that was extremely true of him.

MR: Did you follow — sort of stay with his music as it progressed to the end of his life? Some of those LPs, I'll speak for myself, "Ascension" and some of the last LPs were challenging to listen to and I wonder if you, if those LPs had any similarity to effect of "A Love Supreme"?

MC: To be honest I mostly listened to "A Love Supreme." That's kind of what I do. When I find something that really affects me I just listen to it many, many, many, many times, and often don't listen to other recordings by the same person. Of course I did listen to other recordings, but that was the one that affected me the most, the most. Yeah.

MR: Do you listen to your own music?

MC: Rarely. Rarely. Because well if I listen to it many years after I did it it's easier. But if I listen to it too close to the time I did it I'll always hear things that — oh I wish I hadn't done that or I wish I had done thing. Or, you know, and so it can just be disturbing really.

Plus you listen, when you're making a recording and editing it and all that, you listen to it almost ad nauseum so in a way you never want to hear it again sort of.

MR: Tell me what you mean by editing? I remember being really surprised — I mean I have a certain familiarity with the recording studio and what can be done but I remember being very surprised when I heard that classical piano music in particular, performances, can be edited. So are you talking about moving things around or, as we used to say "slicing tape" or are you more talking about just making selections and sequencing them?

MC: Yeah more that. I mean there might be a tiny bit of okay that was really terrible let's cut that ending off and here it went on too long and we didn't like what happens so this is a perfect ending right here. There might be a little bit of that but it's more listening to everything you did, figuring out what works, what doesn't work, what order it should be in, what should the titles be, and then of course mixing the sound, which is always very challenging, very challenging. Because I find that's a very subjective thing and it changes all the time depending on where you are or what equipment you're listening to it on, who's listening to it with you, what mood you're in that day — so yeah.

MR: Yeah it's always tricky if you have the whole band listening to playbacks. Like everybody wants their fader — let me push that up a little bit.

MC: Well the last recording I was on, it was a trio recording with a drummer Harvey Sorgen and a bass player Joe Fonda. Harvey lives up here but he's also on the international circuit, and Joe Fonda played with Braxton for about eleven years or so after I had played with Braxton. And we went into a studio up here and recorded some stuff and when we listened back to it I could barely hear the drums. And so I kept asking them to bring more drums, more drums, more drums. And I could see Harvey was like grinning like you can hear the drums — because I'm always saying less drums, too much drums.

MR: Yes, it's usually the other way around. You've had, been a recipient of a number of grants over the years. An acquaintance of mine said something once that sounded true but I'm not sure and that was organizations don't give out grants for arts that aren't cutting edge. You're not going to get a grant to compose music like Mozart or to play more bebop. Do you think that's true?

MC: As far as my experience goes it depends who's on the panel.

MR: Okay.

MC: It depends who's on the panel. I know I've been asked many times to write things for people applying for grants and to my knowledge no one I've, you know, written things for has actually gotten a grant. And then I just get infuriated because a lot of these people are just brilliant people. I've been on a couple of panels, arts panels. And I think it's really about the quality of the music because I know the New York Foundation for the Arts Panel, when that was happening we all kind of agreed on some very progressive

stuff and then there was like some very beautiful choral stuff that was more traditional. So I don't think that's true across the board. I would say it has more to do — at least in my experience — with the quality of the work.

MR: Good. When you're performing, let's say in a solo context, are you aware of your audience? Are you — how do I say this — trying to imagine what they're hearing. You're hearing what you're playing obviously and do you get caught up in being concerned with what they're quote getting from your performance?

MC: Sometimes. And if I am doing that then I'm not playing as well as I could be playing you know. I'm more concerned with what people are thinking than with being in the flow of what I'm doing. I think that the audience has an energy and I'm very sensitive to energy, musical energy and just psychological energy, just energy of people. So you walk into a room you can sense an energy if people are receptive, and you can sense an energy if people don't like something. And that can be very difficult. I remember one particular instance of playing a concert with my whole heart and I thought it was oh one of the best concerts I've ever played. And afterwards the audience was kind of like [claps lazily]. You know? And I was just like I didn't get it, I felt shattered. And then other times I felt like the music wasn't really that happening but yeah, people loved it. So you really, I think it's a mistake to be concerned with that because what you have, what anyone has to offer is what you are that nobody else is, and I guess that's also part of what I mean by being true — to be you. To play what you are — what's coming out or through you. You know. To let that happen. Again, there are considerations like if you're playing particular music what you're playing has to be appropriate. I mean when I was playing with Braxton and everything I wouldn't break out into some total other kind of music. I just wouldn't. You know but that wasn't because I was thinking about it it just was an obvious feeling so there are all kinds of things like that. I'd say the audience definitely has an effect.

MR: If you were preparing — you're going to walk out on stage and you're just going to improvise. I have two questions about that. Is there something you do to prepare and how do you know when you're done?

MC: Well before I go out I usually pace around a lot and I'm always, I always have this kind of nervous energy. Always a little nervous I guess. Sometimes I will just go out and have no idea what I'm going to do. Other times I'll think beforehand I want to start in such and such a way.

MR: Would that include — I'm sorry — would that include picking a chord to start with?

MC: It could.

MR: Okay.

MC: It could. Or a rhythm or a feeling. And usually I'll be, you know, playing certain pieces at any given time so if I'm playing a concert I might bring one of those pieces in. I might decide beforehand I want to play such and such composition, either mine or somebody else's. And you know sometimes I'll think I want to do a certain thing and I'll start trying to do it and it's just not happening and eventually I have to give up and go, literally, where the music is taking me you know. And then I've kind of wasted the past five minutes or whatever, trying to force it into a particular direction where I wanted it to go, but that is just not what's happening at that moment. So yeah, it's all about being open to energy and being willing to go in a different direction and also when you're playing with other people like sometimes I'll really hear a particular direction, the music going in a particular direction. and the other people aren't going there. And you know, you could try to force it or gently nudge it in that direction, but then if it's not going there you just have to say okay. You know?

MR: Maybe next time.

MC: Or not.

MR: Or not. I love the bass, I love the stand-up bass and I've often felt that it can be the most predominant effecting instrument in a group. And if the bass player goes somewhere, either time-wise and feel-wise or harmonically I guess you have to decide yeah all right, I'm going to go with you or maybe not.

MC: Um hum. Yeah. I think there's a lot of truth in that. Going with somebody also has to has different connotations to me. Like okay you could try to join them in the harmonies that they're playing, or you could try to play— not go with them in that way but do something that would be different but still work with what they're doing. You know? And in fact sometimes when I was improvising ballads with the trio I would just start playing something, changing harmonies and all that. And I would tell people, "Don't try to play with me, that's not the sound I want." You know? Like somebody scrambling to catch me on a particular harmony or something. That's not what I want, it's more of a kind of collage concept. More like instead of like this [clasps hands tightly] more kind of [indicates loosely joined hands]. You know?

MR: Yeah you gave me a flash of listening to some Billie Holiday records where she was so far — not so far, but she was really quite behind the beat. I wondered like did the musicians accompanying her ever feel like okay, we should slow down.

MC: No. Well no. I wouldn't think so because I would think they were keeping the thing, they were keeping the structure happening which allowed her to be very flexible.

MR: Did you ever — this is an odd question — watching you play on some videos, did you ever feel that the piano wasn't enough for what you wanted to say?

MC: Yeah. I used to feel that. I wanted to sing, I wanted other kinds of sounds, I wanted to be able to sustain and change a sound after I had played it which you can't really do on a string instrument or a wind or a brass instrument, where vocally you can start soft and get louder. Well you can't do that — once you hit the piano key that's it. So I mean there are a lot of things, sounds you can get from the instrument inside the piano with the wood and stuff like that, singing into the piano. So all of those are impossible but yeah.

MR: Did you ever take a dab into electronic instruments?

MC: It's interesting, you're asking all these questions of things I've just been like thinking and talking about with people. I've always been attracted to electronics, more to pure sound design kind of things as opposed to samples of instruments and stuff like that. I have never worked with it because I never had a lot of confidence in myself as far as technology went, which I guess is one of my flaws. So if I hear certain types of sounds I'll usually just hire somebody like David Rothenberg or Richard Teitelbaum who plays synthesizer or laptop electronics and tell them what kinds of sounds I want, or work with a recording engineer to get certain kinds of sounds, actually, in the studio. But yeah, some very attractive, especially when I was working with dancers and sometimes creating music for them for performances, I always heard electronic things happening, things that would not tie everything down, yeah, that wouldn't tie everything down, that would be more open, more abstract, pure sound.

MR: I'm trying to think if it was an album you did, apparently some of the album had two pianos that were not in tune on purpose.

MC: Yeah. Wow, you know that one.

MR: Where did that idea come from?

MC: Well that was with this German pianist Georg Graewe and we just had the idea to do a duo recording. We went to this piano factory to look at pianos and the master tuner there said he was working with all these different tunings and would we like to try something with one of those tunings, and we said yes. That's how that came about. And I love that recording. It sounds like music from outer space.

MR: I think of Sun Ra for some reason when you said that. Yeah. Are you affected by music from other cultures? Gamelan and so forth?

MC: Yeah, yeah. Very much, very, very much, folk music from everywhere, especially Africa, all the different African countries. Amazing music. Amazing folk music from all over the world really. I also love Scandinavian folk music very much and I remember when I first listened to a recording I was expecting, I don't know what I was expecting, some like jigs or waltzes or polkas or something. And it was this wild, very like keening across the mountain kind of thing. It sounded to me very much like some Irish folk music. And well there was a lot of interchange there with the Vikings you know. So they are actually

connected, they're related. One of the people I met in recent years is a woman named Benedicte Maurseth. And she plays a Norwegian Hardanger fiddle which has extra strings so there's a lot of resonance there. And she has done some very beautiful things. So I've been listening to her things and Elena Villamar is a Swedish singer who sings Swedish music and plays violin and is very intense. She grew up in the North of Sweden. Her grandmother saw little people there. Anyway —

MR: Interesting. When you worked with the Creative Music Workshop, did you find that you needed to come up with some new terms to teach creativity, not normally that you'd use in a music lesson or a piano lesson. How did you get across some of these more abstract thoughts?

MC: Actually I don't think I so much teach creative music as sort of get people playing and investigating their own creativity. Because I don't think you can teach creativity but you can help people to open up to their creativity. And that said, I do a lot of things with the collage concept and putting pieces together where different people have ideas and then we put them together as a kind of collage and create pieces. And they're amazing. I mean people come up with things I could never imagine.

MR: I love that, I used to work in the field of aesthetic education and people would, as you said, come up with things like how did you think of that? And I found that often I attributed it to the fact that they weren't that skilled in a particular area, and they looked at it differently.

MC: That could be part of it, or sometimes they go to a place where they are more comfortable, like people will often start off very shy in some of these workshops at like just the community centers, whatever, especially teenagers, younger teenagers. And then next thing I know they're up in front of everybody doing this incredible monologue and just, you know. And I remember in particular doing a workshop at a community center in Massachusetts and there were these two girls who — we were going around like everybody do a few seconds of something, just going around in a circle you know. And when it came to them they would just shake their heads no and everything. And I would say okay, you know, just go on to the next person. And then I put people together or let them put themselves together in groups of two. And that was the magic solution, because suddenly when these girls could do something together they weren't really shy anymore. And they did this whole kind of theater improvisation about not knowing what to do.

MR: I bet you felt good after that session.

MC: Yeah.

MR: Yeah. Something to remember. Do you have an opinion about this — this is a large question — the state of jazz in the United States currently? It's obviously been embraced

by academia but if you look at such things as record sales and venues it's a different story. Do you have any thoughts on that?

MC: Yeah. I don't know. I mean my experience of playing in the States has pretty much been very open, receptive audiences. "Oh, why haven't we heard this before? Where can we find records or recordings? Whatever. And people are very open and interested. And it's more the middlemen, the agents or non-existent agents or whatever. It all comes down to money. Like are we going to make money with this, are we going to get an audience? "No, we're not going to do it because we'll lose money" has been more of an issue here than say in Europe, although things have started changing over there as well. So I don't really know. I mean it's hard to say now, especially these past two years. Because most venues haven't been able to operate. And you know I know there are places everywhere. There is a large network of places to perform in this country. However, many of them just don't have budgets where they can afford to bring people in and pay them, you know, a reasonable fee. But it's not just music, I think it's the state of the arts in general. You know as far as I can tell, the visual art world is very much about money and who's a name and you know there might be some fabulous, fabulous artist who isn't known, and they can't sell their work but then there's somebody who is known whose work is, you know, I don't know. I hate to be critical or I'll say questionable, but they sell for millions and millions of dollars because such-and-such a person did it. You know? So on one level that's the state of the arts. But there's a tremendous amount of creative energy I think in this country and in the world, and I think there's enormous potential here for a lot more to happen, a lot more. If there would just be some kind of support and — it's difficult because there are some things like the NEA you know, and there was the Lila Wallace Reader's Digest Fund for a while which funded various touring groups. But that's only a very small portion of everything and everyone that could be doing that. It's better than nothing, but there's a lot more that could be done. And I've often thought if I was in charge of the arts in this country I would set up all kinds of regional arts programs and interchangeable programs touring and education. I just heard that SUNY New Paltz — State University of New York at New Paltz — has cut out a tremendous number of their music programs.

MR: Oh dear.

MC: Because of Covid and it wasn't financially viable anymore. You know? So there is a perception in a certain way that the arts are frivolous and unnecessary and there are more important places for money to go. Yes, people need places to live and medical care and education and they need to eat, but it's like the arts are the soul of a people, of the country. And if you don't nourish that then you're really starving the human spirit of that country.

MR: Well said. Do you feel you've ever been at a disadvantage — or I should say an advantage — because you are a woman jazz musician? Or a creative musician?

MC: I never did feel that. I never did feel that because of the milieu that I was in. It was really about the music and who could play the music. You know? There was never a thought of is it a woman or a man, whatever, at least to my knowledge there mostly wasn't. You know? Sometimes when it would come to people promoting festivals or things like that, looking back on it maybe I was overlooked at various times in areas where I should have not been overlooked you know. But in general I think that I can't really complain. I think I've had a wonderful — I don't want to say it 'cause it sounds like it's the end of my life — but I think I've had a wonderful life so far. And the opportunities and the people I've had the opportunities to play with and the places I've been able to go to and the people I've been able to meet and the cultures I've been able to experience, you know, it's a dream. It's what I would have dreamed I would have wanted to do when I was younger.

MR: That's wonderful to hear, and it sounds like a pretty good place to wrap up. I had one more question about — if you were about to go on stage, let's say you were in some "green room" and there was a television on showing the news and the news just was very aggravating, do you think it would affect your performance?

MC: First of all I would turn it off immediately. I would turn it off. Because it could possibly affect it and you know you're trying to be in a certain space and yeah, for me personally I would just walk in at that moment and turn it off.

MR: But would a generally bad day — I guess what I'm trying to ask is does the music that you create operate separately from how your day went? How your general mood is? Can you make that happen?

MC: Yes and no. Yes and no. It's like when you go up on the stage you have to be able to put those things aside and just try to get into that space, you know, almost more like a meditative kind of space. Because there's always going to be something happening and going on. On the other hand, yeah, it can't help but affect how you're feeling and that's going to come out through the music. But yeah, if you're up there thinking oh such-and-such a person was mean to me, or blah-blah, or this and that happened in the world today, yeah, world events, things that happen, they definitely affect me profoundly. And so they're probably in there in the mix somewhere. Maybe not always on a conscious level.

MR: Well thank you. It's been very informative and I love to meet the people behind the interesting music. I wish we were doing this face to face.

MC: Yeah. Well we almost are.

MR: We almost are. And I wish that, I hope things open up for you as for all artists and they can get back to the work at hand.

MC: Thank you. You know could I say one more thing about the arts in this country — and I know I'm going to think of a million more things I wish I had said after this is over — but like I said there is a network of places, like the Outpost in Albuquerque, Tom Guralnick's place. There are things happening everywhere and especially, especially important I think is what William and Patricia Parker have been doing in New York with the Vision Festival. I think that is really one of our most significant festivals, maybe our most significant festival in North America for creative music. There was also the Vancouver Jazz Festival when Ken Pickering was alive, he just brought in everyone you know, from North America, from overseas, all the interesting music he heard in the world he just brought it all in. So it's not like nothing is happening. There are wonderful things happening it just doesn't get enough support and there's not enough of it, but I did want to mention the Vision Festival because I think it's so important what they're doing.

MR: Thank you. Well I appreciate the conversation today and I hope you go to your piano and write something new today.

MC: Well I might. I've been feeling more like playing than I have this whole time.

MR: All right. Thanks a lot.

MC: Thanks Monk. If you ever come around this area, please give a call, we can actually meet in person.

MR: I will. And I'm just going to pause our recording and then we'll say good-bye.

MC: Okay.